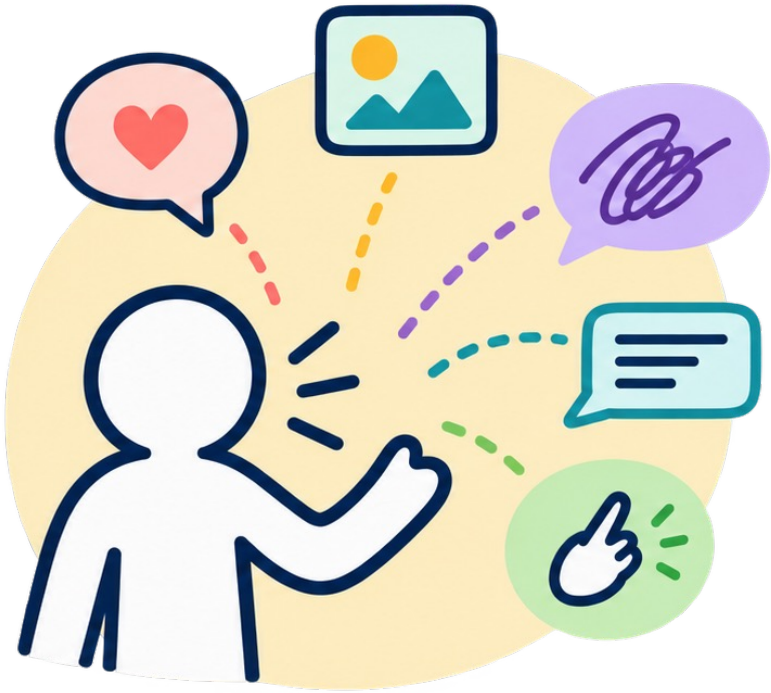




School Leadership · Session 3

Autistic Experience at School:

**Communication, Connection
and Identity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



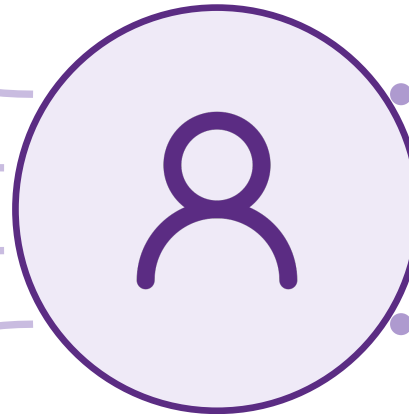
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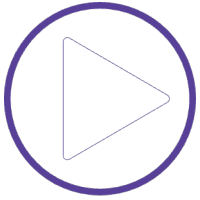


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



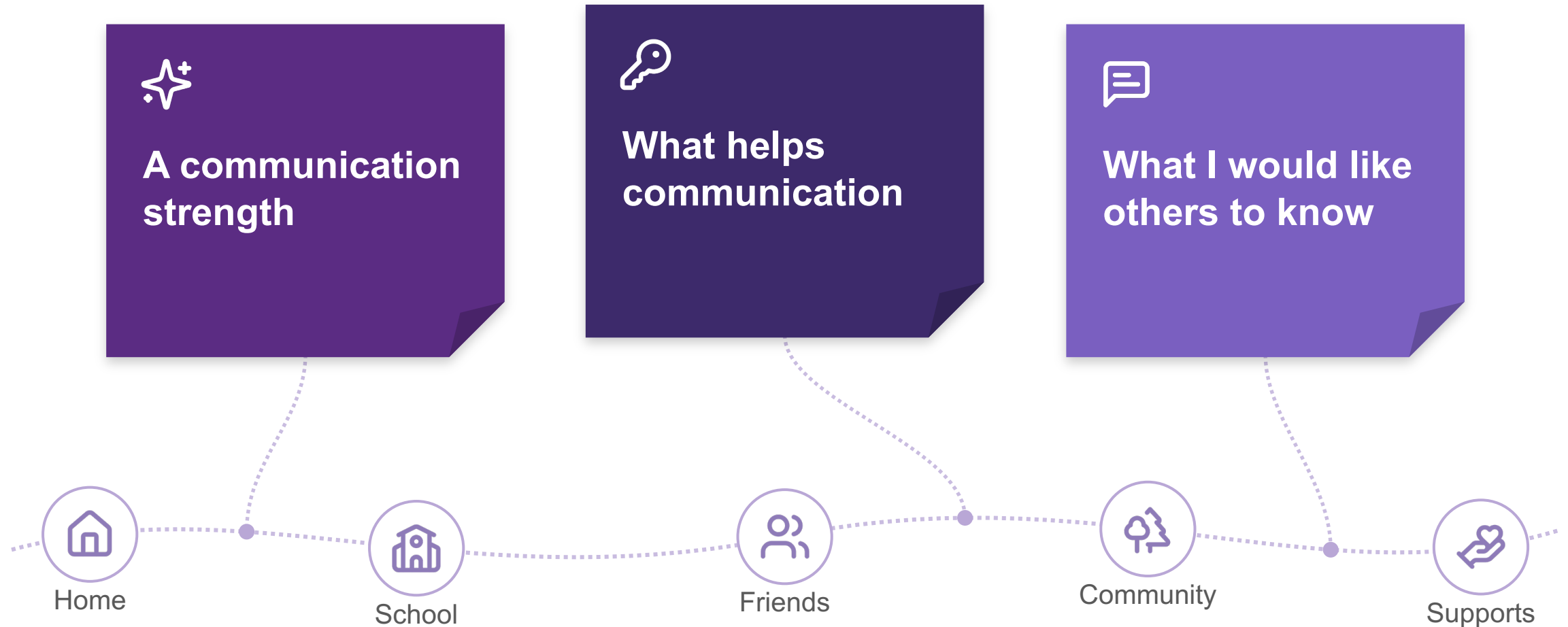
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

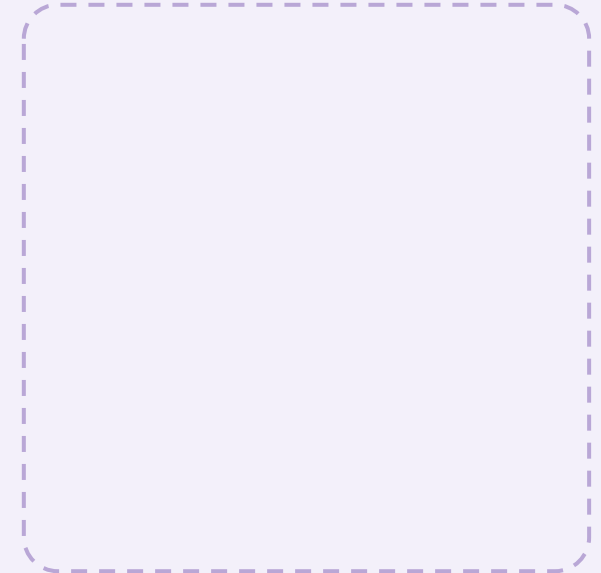
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

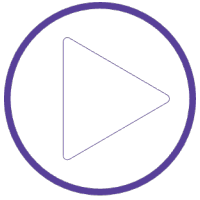


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

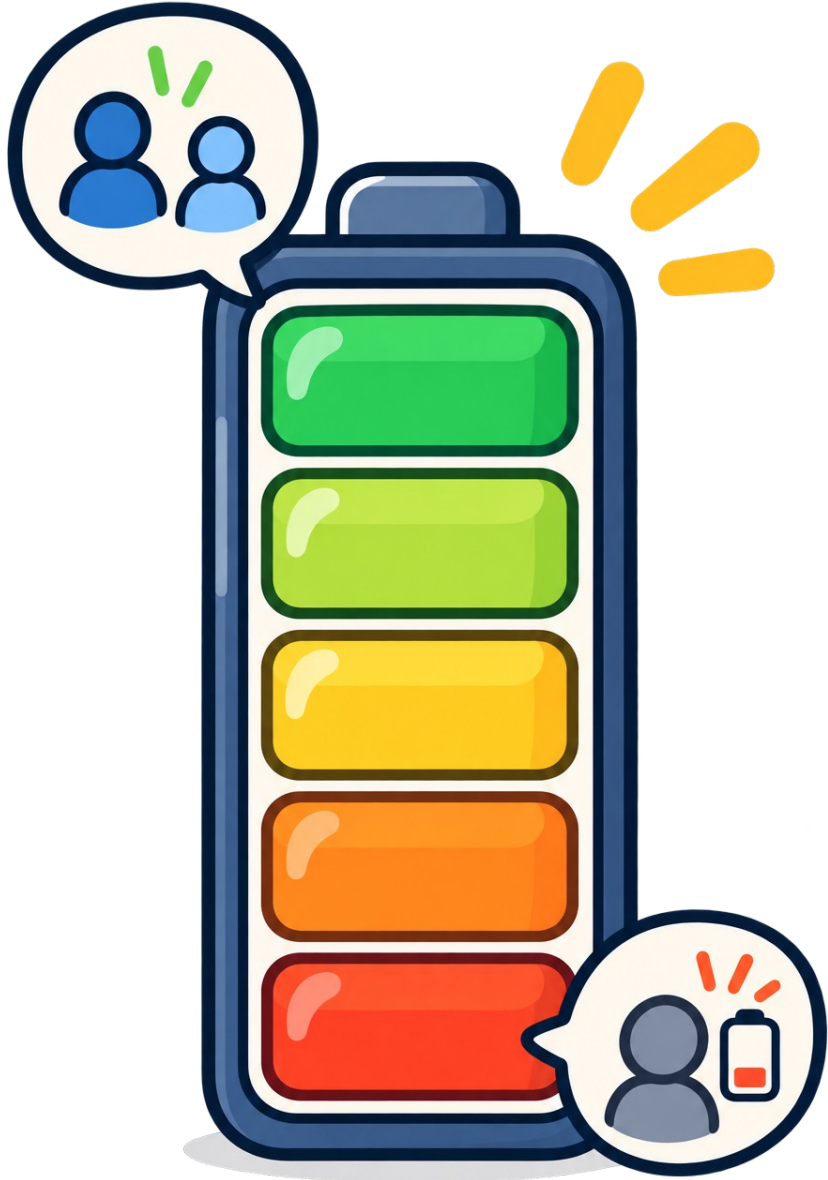


Discussion activity



- When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?
- What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of a student's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.



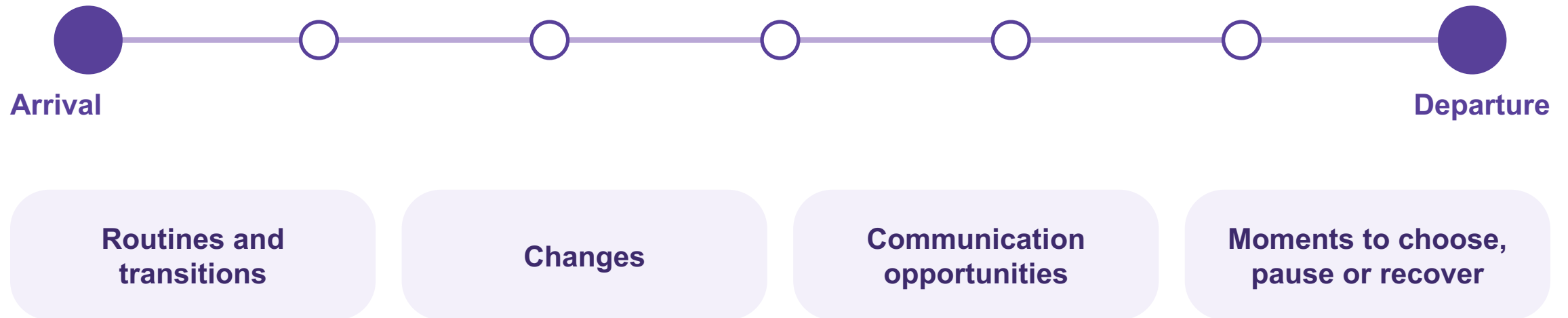
Fluctuating Capacity



Map a school day

Follow a typical school day as your students experience it.

Include whole-school routines: bells, assemblies, breaks, relief days and changes. Then mark how the same moments affect each of the students you have in mind.



What costs? What lightens?

Return to the day map.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand?

What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Record questions rather than claiming to know an internal state.

The school-day stack

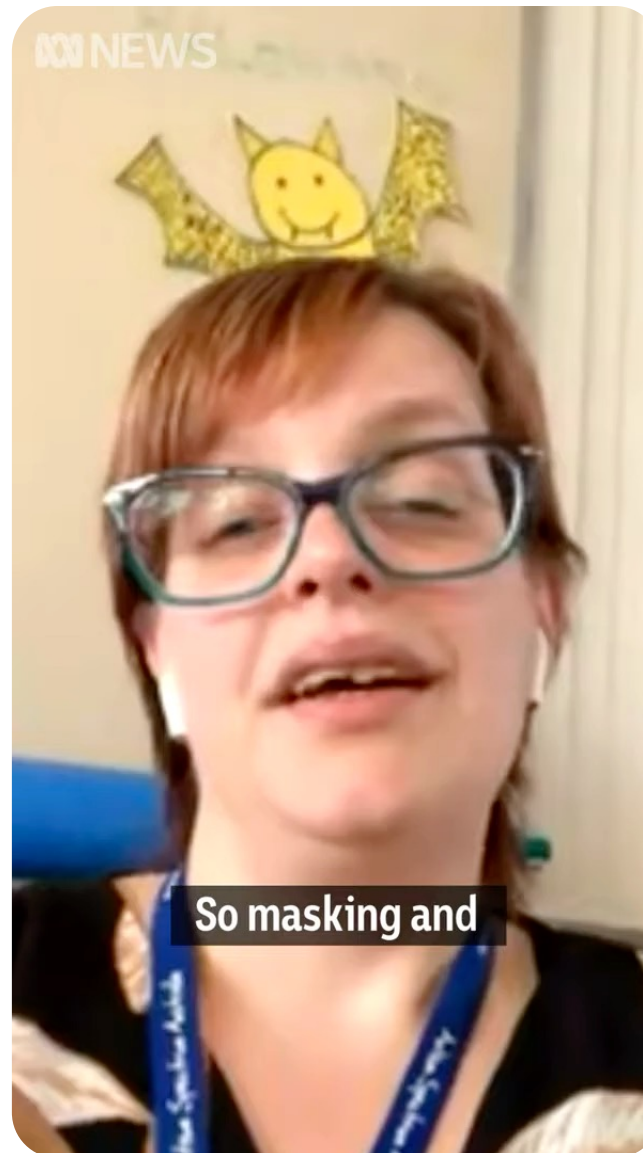
Notice what accumulates across the whole day.

A moment that seems small in isolation may sit within many demands. Include supports, relief and recovery as well as cost.





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Discussion activity



- When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear “fine” at school when they are not?
- When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Your Autistic staff

Everything today about students also applies to staff.

Some of your staff are Autistic

whether or not they have told anyone. They notice how safe the culture is.

The same load

Sensory load, masking and energy all apply in the staffroom and in meetings.

Strengths they bring

Deep knowledge, precision and real connection with neurodivergent students.

Adjustments for staff

Predictable meetings, clear communication, choice in how to contribute, and quiet space.

Build a culture where it is safe to be open, and never ask anyone to disclose.

Audit at school level

Choose one school-level routine or process. What may its impact be, and why?

- 1 Name the routine or process.
- 2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.
- 3 List possible environmental or task contributors.
- 4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Choose one to audit:

Enrolment and starting at the school · assemblies · relief-day arrangements · how change is communicated · where students can go to regulate.

Carry into design

Choose a clear focus for the next session.

Keep

One school practice to keep because it supports access, connection or joy

Reduce

One barrier or unnecessary demand to reduce

Explore

One question to explore with students, families or staff

Keep students first.

Positive Autistic Identity

A child who knows who they are -
and feels genuinely valued for it -
has more available for everything
else.

